

prompted by Gesualdo's wish to spend time in her home town of Ferrara, which was renowned for fostering composers and performers of madrigals. Over the following few years, he established a similar musical set-up in his castle at Gesualdo in Avellino, and began composing in earnest.

Devotion and isolation

The first of Gesualdo's books of madrigals was written in Ferrara, and was followed by five further volumes and two sets of *Sacrae cantiones*.

His devotion to composition led to the breakdown of his marriage, with Leonora spending increasingly long periods with her brother, especially after the death of their son, Alfonsino, in 1600. Gesualdo became ever more reclusive, never leaving his estate, and suffered constant depression, which drove him to acts of self-flagellation. The death of his son Emanuele by his first marriage appears to have been the final straw, as he died only three weeks after him, in 1613.